

Eric A. Pelzl

The Hong Kong Polytechnic University
Hong Hom, Kowloon, Hong Kong

eric.pelzl@polyu.edu.hk

EDUCATION

- 2018 **Ph.D., Second Language Acquisition**
University of Maryland, College Park
Advisor: Robert DeKeyser (Second Language Acquisition)
Committee members: Ellen Lau (Linguistics), Kira Gor (Second Language Acquisition), Scott Jackson (Center for Advanced Study of Language), Colin Phillips (Linguistics, Dean's Representative)
Dissertation Title: "Second language lexical representation and processing of Mandarin Chinese tones"
- 2010 **M.A., Chinese**
Middlebury College
Advisor: Jianhua Bai
Thesis Title: "Sentence processing in Chinese as a second language: A study of word order and the influence of event probabilities on the assignment of agent and patient roles"
- 2003 **M.Div.**
Wisconsin Lutheran Seminary
- 1999 **B.A., Pastoral Ministry**
Martin Luther College

PROFESSIONAL APPOINTMENTS

- 2025-*present* Assistant Professor, Department of Language Science and Technology, The Hong Kong Polytechnic University
- 2023-2025 Assistant Professor, Department of Chinese and Bilingual Studies, The Hong Kong Polytechnic University
- 2022-2023 Postdoctoral fellow, Center for Language Science, Penn State University
- 2020-2022 NSF SBE postdoctoral fellow, Penn State University
Advisors: Matthew Carlson (Spanish & Linguistics), Carrie Jackson (German & Linguistics), Janet van Hell (Psychology & Linguistics)
- 2018-2020 Postdoctoral fellow, Center for Language Science, Penn State University
- 2011-2012 Assistant Professor of Mandarin Chinese, Wisconsin Lutheran College
- 2007-2011 Instructor of Mandarin Chinese, Wisconsin Lutheran College

FELLOWSHIPS AND GRANTS

- 2024 RGC Early Career Scheme grant (25616024)
- 2023 PolyU Start-up Funds for New Recruits (P0049349)
- 2020 NSF SBE Postdoctoral Research Fellowship (NSF grant 2004279)
- 2017 NSF Linguistics Program-Doctoral Dissertation Research Improvement Award (NSF grant 1728851)
- 2017 Ann G. Wylie Dissertation Fellowship
- 2015 NSF-EAPSI Fellowship (summer research program in Beijing, China)

- (NSF grant 1514936)
- 2013 NSF-IGERT Fellowship (interdisciplinary training at University of Maryland)
- 2012 Graduate Research Assistantship, Center for Advanced Study of Language
- 2009 The Kathryn Davis Fellowship for Peace, Middlebury College

PUBLICATIONS

Refereed Journal Articles

- Pelzl, E.** (2025) High variability orthographic training: Learning words in a logographic script through training with multiple typefaces. *Psychonomic Bulletin and Review*. <https://doi.org/10.3758/s13423-025-02646-0>
- Pelzl, E., Jończyk, R. van Hell, J. G.** (2024) Second language knowledge can influence native language performance in exclusively native contexts: An approximate replication of Van Hell & Dijkstra (2002). *Studies in Second Language Acquisition*.
- Pelzl, E., Liu, J., Qi, C.** (2022) Native language experience with tones influences both phonetic and lexical processes when acquiring a second tonal language. *Journal of Phonetics*. 95, 101197. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.wocn.2022.101197>
- Pelzl, E., Lau, E., Guo, T., DeKeyser, R., C.** (2021a) Even in the best-case scenario L2 learners have persistent difficulty perceiving and utilizing tones in Mandarin: Findings from behavioral and ERP experiments. *Studies in Second Language Acquisition*. 43(2), 268-296. <https://doi.org/10.1017/S027226312000039X>
- Pelzl, E., Lau, E., Guo, T., DeKeyser, R., C.** (2021b) Advanced second language learners of Mandarin show persistent deficits for lexical tone encoding in picture-to-word form matching. *Frontiers in Communication*. 6, 117. <https://www.frontiersin.org/articles/10.3389/fcomm.2021.689423/full>
- Pelzl, E., Lau, E. F., Jackson, S. R., Guo, T., Gor, K.** (2021) Behavioral and neural responses to tone errors in foreign-accented Mandarin. *Language Learning*. 71(2), 414-452. <https://doi.org/10.1111/lang.12438>
- Pelzl, E., Carlson, M. T., Guo, T., Jackson, C. N., van Hell, J. G.** (2021) Tuning out tone errors? Native listeners do not down-weight tones when hearing unsystematic tone errors in foreign-accented Mandarin. *Bilingualism: Language and Cognition*. 24(1), 215-222. <https://doi.org/10.1017/S1366728920000280>
- Pelzl, E.** (2019). What makes perception of Mandarin tones difficult for second language learners: A non-technical review of evidence from psycholinguistic research. *Chinese as a Second Language*. 54(1), 51-78. <https://doi.org/10.1075/csl.18009.pel>
- Pelzl, E., Lau, E., Guo, T., DeKeyser, R., C.** (2019). Advanced second language learners' perception of lexical tone contrasts. *Studies in Second Language Acquisition*. 41(1), 59-86. <https://doi.org/10.1017/S0272263117000444>

Book Chapters

- Pelzl, E., Zhang, H.** (forthcoming) Tone. In I. Kecskes and Y. Zhao (Ed.) *Development and Use of Chinese as a Second Language*, Cambridge University Press.
- Pelzl, E.** (2024). A few thoughts on how to learn a few thousand characters. In C. Chu, M. Coss, and P. N. Zhang (Ed.) *Transforming L2 Hanzì Teaching and Learning in the Age of Digital Writing (电写时代汉字教学的理论与实践)*, Routledge.
- Dickson, D. S., **Pelzl, E.** (2023). Using time-based encephalography to investigate second language. In K. Morgan-Short and J. van Hell (Ed.) *The Routledge Handbook of Second Language Acquisition and Neurolinguistics* (pp. 17-30), Routledge.

Pelzl, E. (2021) Foreign-accent in second language Mandarin Chinese. In C. Yang (Ed.) *The acquisition of Chinese as a second language pronunciation: Segments and prosody* (pp. 257-279). Singapore: Springer.

Cook, S. V., Sweet, S. J., Lancaster, A., Pandža, N. B., Jackson, S. R., **Pelzl, E.**, Gor, K., Doughty, C. J. (2018) Linguistic Correlates of Proficiency (LCP): At the intersection of testing and teaching. In J. M. Davis, et al. (Ed.), *Useful Assessment and Evaluation in Language Education*. Washington, D.C: Georgetown University Press.

Other Publications

Pelzl, E., (2026) L2 Tone Learning. In Chapelle, C.A. (Ed.) *The Encyclopedia of Applied Linguistics*. Wiley.

In Preparation/Review

Pelzl, E., Tatsumi, Y., Cui, Z., Viswanathan, N., Olmstead, A. J. (*in review*) Studying Mandarin tone sandhi in interaction.

Pelzl, E. (*in prep*) Investigating the effects of variable typeface training with naïve learners of Chinese characters: improved generalization comes at a cost

Pelzl, E., Cui, Z. (*in prep*) An ERP investigation of adaptation to bad maps (mispronunciation) in L2 accented speech

Pelzl, E., Carlson, M. T., Jackson, C. N., van Hell, J. G. (*in prep*) Frequent pronunciation errors in foreign-accented speech drive down-weighting of phonological cues

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

2023-present	Assistant Professor, Assistant Professor, Department of Chinese and Bilingual Studies, The Hong Kong Polytechnic University
2023	Instructor, Penn State Linguistics program
2021	Instructor, Penn State Linguistics program
2011 & 2012	Chinese School Faculty (Level II), Middlebury Chinese Language School
2006-2007	Adjunct Instructor of Mandarin Chinese, Wisconsin Lutheran College
2005-2006	English Teacher, The World Language Center, Fongyuan, Taiwan
2005	Volunteer Ancient Greek and ESL Teacher, Asia Lutheran Seminary, Hong Kong
2003-2004	English Teacher, Wenling High School, Wenling, Zhejiang

COURSES TAUGHT

The Hong Kong Polytechnic University

CBS3402: Psycholinguistics (Fall, 2023; Spring 2025, 2026)
CBS506: Educational Linguistics (Spring, 2024, 2025, 2026)
CBS5RT01/5R05: Professional Ethics and Academic Integrity (Spring, 2025)
CBS4701: Project in Language Studies (2023-2026)
CBS592: Psycholinguistics (Spring 2024; Fall 2025, 2026)
CBS1A13: The Talking Brain (Fall, 2023)

Penn State University

LING525: Experimental Research Methods in Psycholinguistics (Spring 2023)
LING447: Bilingualism (Spring, 2021)

Wisconsin Lutheran College

Chinese 1 (Fall, 2006-2011)

Chinese 2 (Spring, 2006-2010, 2012)

Chinese 3 (Fall, 2006-2010)

Chinese 4 (Spring, 2006-2011)

Chinese 5 (Fall, 2007-2009)

Chinese 6 (Spring, 2007-2009, 2011)

Modern Chinese Media 1: Television (Fall, 2011)

Modern Chinese Media 2: Newspapers and Blogs (Spring 2012)

Middlebury Chinese Language School

Intermediate Chinese (Summer 2011 and 2012)

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

Pelzl, E. (accepted) *More is not always better: Using multiple typefaces while learning Chinese characters may not be advantageous, even if it improves initial generalization abilities.* Poster to be presented at the The Joint ESCoP-CoPM Meeting 2026, Hangzhou, China.

Pelzl, E. (2026) *High Variability Orthographic Training: Investigating the effects of using multiple typefaces while learning Chinese characters.* Talk presented at the third Greater Bay PERL, Hong Kong.

Yang, Y., **Pelzl, E.** (2026) *Categorical and Gradient Perception of Lexical Tones in L2 Cantonese Acquisition.* Poster presented at International Symposium on Language Science (ISLS) 2026, Hong Kong, China.

Cui, Z., **Pelzl, E.** (2025) *Native listeners tolerate tonal pronunciation errors (bad maps) in Cantonese-accented Mandarin.* Poster presented at 3rd International Conference on Tone and Intonation, Herrsching, Germany.

Pelzl, E., Olmstead, A. J., Viswanathan, N. (2023) *Studying Mandarin Tone sandhi in interaction.* Poster presented at 184th Meeting of the Acoustical Society of America, Chicago, Illinois.

Pelzl, E. (2022) *High Variability Orthographic Training: Learning Words in a Morphosyllabic Script Through Training with Multiple Fonts.* Paper presented at 63rd annual meeting of the Psychonomic Society, New Orleans, LA.

Pelzl, E. (2022) *Using a variety of fonts to train Chinese characters: A simple technique that can enhance character learning.* Paper presented at 2022 Chinese Language Teachers Association Annual Conference.

Pelzl, E., Carlson, M. T., Jackson, C. N., van Hell, J. G. (2021) *When a second language speaker produces frequent pronunciation errors, native listeners can learn to treat the mis-produced sounds as less informative.* Poster presented at 62nd annual meeting of the Psychonomic Society, New Orleans, LA.

Liu, Jiang, **Pelzl, E.** (2021) *Negative and Positive Influence of Tones: Vietnamese Speakers' Perception of Tones and Recognition of (Tone) Words in L2 Mandarin.* Paper presented at the 46th Boston University Conference on Language Development (BUCLD), Boston, MA.

Pelzl, E., Carlson, M. T., Jackson, C. N., van Hell, J. G. (2021) *When L2 tone errors are extremely frequent, Mandarin listeners will ignore (some of) them.* Paper presented at 33rd North American Conference on Chinese Linguistics, Chicago, IL.

Pelzl, E. (2021) *The enduring difficulty of tones: Results of tone and word recognition experiments with advanced L2 Chinese learners.* Paper accepted at Chinese Language Teachers Association Annual Conference.

Pelzl, E., Carlson, M. T., Jackson, C. N., van Hell, J. G. (2020*) *Frequent tone errors have*

- little effect on Chinese listeners' responses to accurately produced foreign-accented words.* Paper accepted at American Association for Applied Linguistics (AAAL), Denver, CO. (*cancelled due to COVID-19)
- Pelzl, E.,** Lau, E. F., Guo, T., DeKeyser, R. (2018) *Suprasegmental difficulties are not superficial: An ERP study of tone word recognition in advanced second language learners of Mandarin Chinese.* Paper presented at Second Language Research Forum, Montreal, Canada.
- Pelzl, E.,** Lau, E. F., Guo, T., DeKeyser, R. (2018) *Tonal word recognition in adult advanced second language learners of Mandarin Chinese.* Poster presented at Multidisciplinary Approaches to Child and Adult Language Acquisition, Penn State.
- Pelzl, E.** (2018) *The role of accent in Chinese listeners' comprehension of second language Mandarin speech.* Paper presented at Chinese Language Teachers Association Annual Conference, Herndon, VA.
- Pelzl, E.,** Lau, E., DeKeyser, R. (2018) *The processing of tones and segments in Mandarin word recognition by advanced second language learners.* Poster presented at American Association for Applied Linguistics (AAAL) 2018 Conference, Chicago, IL.
- Pelzl, E.** (2016) *What makes hearing Mandarin tones difficult for second language learners? Evidence from psycholinguistic research.* Paper presented at Chinese Language Teachers Association Second International Symposium on Chinese Teaching and Learning (CLTA-S2), College Park, MD.
- Pelzl, E.,** Guo, T., Lau, E. (2016) *Tuning in: adaptation to mispronunciation in foreign-accented sentence comprehension.* Poster presented at the twenty-ninth annual CUNY conference on human sentence processing, University of Florida, Gainesville, FL.
- Pelzl, E.,** DeKeyser, R., Lau, E., Phillips, C. (2015). *Advanced second language learners' perception of lexical tone contrasts.* Paper presented at the thirty-fourth Second Language Research Forum (SLRF), Atlanta, GA.
- Pelzl, E.** (2015). (2015). *A proof-of-concept study for measuring receptive written vocabulary size in second language Chinese.* Poster presented at the fourteenth annual conference of the East Coast Organization of Language Testers (ECOLT), Georgetown University, Washington D.C.
- Pelzl, E.,** Vafae, P., Chrabaszc, A., Cook, S., Gor, K., Jackson, S. R., Jiang, N., Lancaster, A., Li, C., Li, M., Long, M. H., Pandža, N. B., Zhou, Q. (2014). *Linguistic Correlates of Proficiency.* Paper presented at the thirteenth annual conference of the East Coast Organization of Language Testers (ECOLT), New York, NY.
- Vafae, P., Suzuki, Y., **Pelzl, E.** (2014). *How Aptitude-treatment Interaction studies can benefit Learning-oriented Assessment.* Paper presented at the Teachers College Columbia University Roundtable in Second Language Studies, New York, NY.
- Cook, S., Bonilla, C., **Pelzl, E.,** Miller, C., Prado, T. T., Overfelt, C., Siegel, J., Vatz, K., Clark, C., Jackson, S., Doughty, C. (2014). *Language Aptitude and L2 Lexical Learning.* Paper presented at annual conference of the American Association for Applied Linguistics, Portland, OR.
- Pelzl, E.** (2009). *Zhōngwén shì hěn nán: Using processing instruction to address common learner errors in Chinese.* Paper presented at the annual conference of the Wisconsin Association for Language Teachers, Appleton, WI.
- Pelzl, E.** (2008) *Zhongxi-hebi: making effective use of ESL ideas in the teaching of Chinese.* Paper presented at the annual conference of the Wisconsin Association for Language Teachers, Appleton, WI.

AWARDS

- 2016 Tao-Chung Ted Yao Memorial Award (CLTA conference presentation)
 2016 Best Teaching Activity Award, CLTA-S2 conference

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

- 2016-2017 Graduate Assistant, Academic Technology Experience team, Division of Information Technology, University of Maryland, College Park
 2012-2016 Graduate Research Assistant, Center for Advanced Study of Language, University of Maryland, College Park

INVITED GUEST LECTURES AND COLLOQUIA

- Investigating accented speech perception in tonal languages. New Directions Lecture Series, Hong Kong Polytechnic University (4/14/2026)
 Investigating accented speech perception in tonal languages. Invited seminar at Center for Chinese Linguistics, The Hong Kong University of Science and Technology (4/24/2025)
 How do listeners respond to frequent pronunciation errors in L2 speech? Insights from research with Mandarin lexical tones. University of Maryland Second Language Acquisition invited lecture series (2/24/2022)
 Foreign-accented Mandarin: It's all about tones, right? Invited talk for the Pronunciation Special Interest Group of the Chinese Language Teachers Association (01/07/2021)
 Investigating Foreign-Accented Speech in a Tonal Language. Invited colloquia at Center for Language Science at Penn State University, University Park, PA (10/30/2020)
 Zhongwen shengdiao weishenme zheme nan xue? (Why are tones so difficult to learn?) Invited online lecture for at Chinese Language Teachers Association Beginning and Intermediate Teacher's Group (6/13/2020, presented in Mandarin)
 What is and isn't hard about learning lexical tones: Research with advanced second language learners of Mandarin Chinese. Invited lecture at Beijing Language and Culture University, Beijing (5/17/2019)
 What is and isn't hard about learning lexical tones: Research with advanced second language learners of Mandarin Chinese. Invited colloquia at Center for Language Science at Penn State University, University Park, PA (9/07/2018)
 What makes hearing Mandarin tones difficult for second language learners? Evidence from psycholinguistic research. Invited lecture with students and faculty from IUP Chinese program at Tsinghua University, Beijing (12/12/2017, presented in Mandarin)
 English native speakers acquisition of Mandarin lexical tones. Invited colloquia at the second annual symposium on corpora and intercultural studies at Shanghai Jiao Tong University, Shanghai (12/01/2017)
 Challenges in Teaching and Learning Chinese: Characters. Invited lecture with students from the ACC K-12 program at Minzu University, Beijing (7/13/2015, presented in Mandarin)
 Processing Instruction and Task Essentialness. Invited online lecture with students from the Monterey Institute of International Studies (10/9/2013, presented in Mandarin)
 My experience learning and teaching Chinese. Invited lecture at Chung Yuan Christian University, Chungli, Taiwan (5/18/2011, presented in Mandarin)

PROFESSIONAL SERVICE

Ad hoc journal reviewer for: *Applied Psycholinguistics*; *Attention, Perception, & Psychophysics*; *Bilingualism: Language and Cognition*; *Chinese as a Second Language*; *International Journal of Bilingual Education and Bilingualism*; *Glossa*; *Journal of the Acoustical Society of America*; *Journal of Chinese Writing Systems*; *Journal of Experimental Psychology: Human Perception and Performance*; *Journal of Memory and Cognition*; *Journal of Memory and Language*; *Journal of Phonetics*; *Journal of Second Language Studies*; *Language, Cognition and Neuroscience*; *Language Learning*; *Language Testing*; *Linguistic Approaches to Bilingualism*; *Linguistics Vanguard*; *The Modern Language Journal*; *Neuropsychologia*; *Psychophysiology*; *Research Methods in Applied Linguistics*; *Second Language Research*; *Speech Communication*; *Studies in Second Language Acquisition*

2025	Proposal reviewer, Bilingualism Matters Symposium (2025)
2025	Proposal reviewer, Pacific Asia Conference on Language, Information and Computation (PACLIC 39)
2020	Proposal reviewer, American Association for Applied Linguistics (AAAL) 2021 Conference
2017	Proposal reviewer, 36th annual Second Language Research Forum
2009-2010	Treasurer, Wisconsin Association of Chinese Language Teachers

INSTITUTIONAL AND DEPARTMENTAL SERVICE

2025-present	Member of SLS lab committee
2025-present	CBS/LST Equal Opportunity Officer
2025-present	Faculty Advisor for the Hong Kong Linguistics Olympiad team
2022	Assist with administration of Penn State Center for Language Science
2019	Member, Penn State Language and Linguistics Day organizing committee
2012-2015	Member, University of Maryland Language Science Day organizing committee
2013	Co-chair, University of Maryland Language Science Day organizing committee
2011	Chair, Wisconsin Lutheran College Faculty Academic Co-curricular Committee
2008-2010	Secretary, Wisconsin Lutheran College Faculty Academic Co-curricular Committee

LANGUAGES

English, native; Mandarin Chinese, fluent

PAST AND PRESENT AFFILIATIONS

Member, American Association for Applied Linguistics
 Member, The Psychonomic Society
 Member, The Chinese Language Teachers Association, USA
 Member, Wisconsin Association of Chinese Language Teachers
 Member, Wisconsin Association for Language Teachers